

The logo for ALTA, consisting of the word "ALTA" in a bold, black, sans-serif font, centered within a white rectangular box with a thin green border.

Design Justification Paper: Maximizing Onboarding Activation and Feature Engagement for Alta

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Course: ITLS 6320

Target Audience: The Alta leadership, engineering, and design teams.

The Goal: This paper explains the reasoning behind the guide's design to Alta's creators, showing how better instructions will keep their customers engaged and stop them from deleting the app.

Introduction:

As a human-centered UX writer, I have personally used and analyzed the digital closet application “Alta.” I have come to appreciate its many potential benefits and tools to make your mornings easier. Alta helps you digitize your closet and gives you the ease to mix and match and save any outfit looks you would like to wear. This makes it easy to use the full potential of your closet and plan your outfits ahead of time. This experience provides great style quality to feel your best, without the excessive time or effort.

To evaluate how new users interact with the platform, I conducted user testing sessions where I observed a target audience member, a busy student, attempting to set up their account and navigate the interface for the first time. During my user research, I noticed a major flaw: the app feels initially complex, its best features are hidden, and it expects users to do a lot of tedious manual labor (photographing an entire closet) with little guidance. This causes new users to get frustrated and abandon the app. To fix this, I researched core UX design principles, using tools like empathy mapping to understand user feelings and Hierarchical Task Analysis (HTA) to break down the app's steps. Using what I learned about how users think, created a written how-to guide and a work-along video to guide and inspire the users of Alta. This paper will discuss the choices made to complete this goal and the justifications for them.

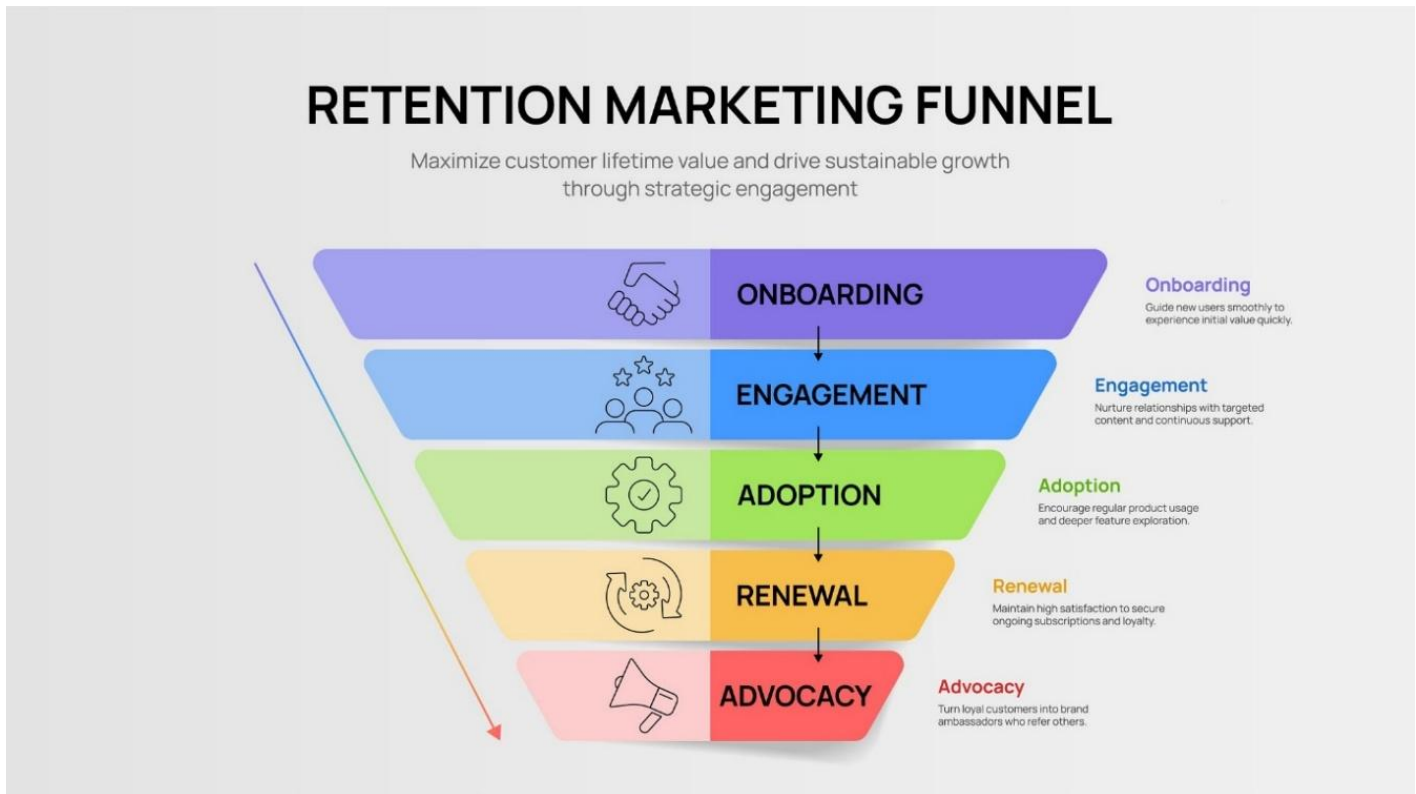
Alta's Core Corporate Goals

To demonstrate business alignment, the instructional how-to guide and presentation are designed to support the client's primary technical and financial objectives directly:

- **Maximize First-Time User Activation:** Digital closet applications suffer from high initial amounts of abandonment due to the chore of manually cataloging all your clothes. The client's primary goal is to accelerate the time until success, guiding users to their first digitized look with minimal friction. Industry benchmarks show that improving onboarding clarity can lift user activation by up to 20% (HubSpot, 2025). The instructional guide actively works to inspire, intrigue, and excite users, pushing them past the doubt phase so they begin scanning their wardrobe right away.
- **Increase Feature Discovery and Adoption:** Alta needs users to adopt advanced features, like the automated email receipt-forwarding system and the AI calendar scheduling engine, to drive long-term retention. The client needs these features prominently highlighted, as undiscovered features can undermine the experience and cause users to lose interest.
- **Reduce Customer Issues:** By proactively addressing common user mistakes (such as poor photo lighting or misaligned AI tags) through clear instructions, the company aims to minimize customer support tickets regarding "failed background crops" or "incorrect data labeling." Customer experience data reveals that clear self-service documentation can deflect up to 30% of standard inbound support requests (Gartner, 2024). If users understand how the AI works best, they can prevent many issues in their experience.
- **Establish Brand Trust and User Delight:** The client wants to build an emotional connection with the user, transforming a simple tool into an intuitive, habit-forming personal stylist. The goal is for Alta to become an app they feel passionate about and excited to use in their daily fashion choices and self-expression.

Visualizing User Drop-Off and Retention

To better understand how these business goals interact, the chart below illustrates the classic retention funnel that digital platforms like Alta must manage.



The Software Retention Funnel. (Reprinted from "Retention Marketing Funnel Infographic," by Getty Images, n.d.).

The how-to guide especially targets the top principles of the retention funnel, onboarding, and engagement. Without clear, empathetic instruction, user engagement drops drastically at the adoption phase due to setup frustration. If we successfully keep our users engaged and interested with ease right from the start, they will find joy in the tool and see how its daily use changes their routine. This naturally leads to user loyalty and brand advocacy, inspiring users to recommend the app to help their loved ones. By smoothing the initial onboarding experience, this design keeps a higher percentage of users moving successfully down the funnel, protecting Alta's long-term business health.

Detailed Analysis of Design Decisions and Justifications

1. Simple Step-by-Step Layout (Taxonomy)

- **The Decision:** The instructional content was mapped into a four-phase chronological taxonomy: *Phase 1: Signing up and Starting*, *Phase 2: Capturing and Digitizing*, *Phase 3: Labeling and Verifying*, and *Phase 4: Creating and Saving a New Look*.
- **The Why:** In technical writing, "taxonomy" is the art and science of dividing a complex subject into distinct groups. If a taxonomy is poorly organized, users experience high cognitive load because they are forced to process unrelated steps simultaneously (Sweller, 1988). By organizing Alta's setup guide in chronological order, the steps naturally match how a user expects a workflow to look. Splitting the process into four distinct phases turns a massive, tedious chore into four simple milestones. This clear structure lowers a beginner's anxiety and turns a boring data-logging task into a predictable, easy-to-follow guide.

2. Clear Word Signals & Headings (Signposting)

- **The Decision:** The guide uses clear order words ("*firstly*," "*second*," "*next*," "*finally*"), starts with an upfront Document Map, and applies big, bold headings to every sub-step.
- **The Why:** In technical writing, "signposting" acts as a navigation aid that tells readers exactly where they are in a document and what is coming next (Markel & Selber, 2021). Using explicit order words helps the user transition smoothly between real-world physical actions (like laying out a shirt) and digital software actions (like tapping a button). Furthermore, most modern users are scanners who only look at a screen for a brief period. Research shows digital readers average less than an 8-second attention span per visual section (Nielsen Norman Group, 2022). Big, bold headings transform a dense technical document into a scannable map, letting a frustrated user skip right to the solution they need without reading the entire guide line-by-line.

3. Everyday Language (No Tech Jargon)

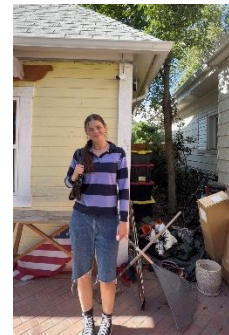
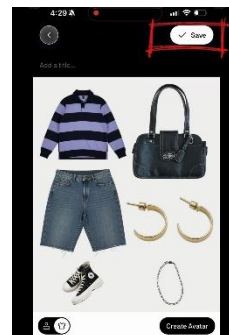
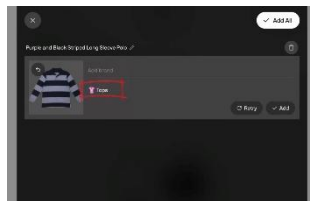
- **The Decision:** Hard-to-understand developer terms were completely removed from the copy (such as *activate render viewport*, *generate clothing compilation*, and

execute file upload node. They were replaced with simple, action-oriented words (like *open the outfit creator*, *start a new look*, and *tap the plus button*).

- **The Why:** Effective UX writing speaks the user's language, not the developer's (Redish, 2012). When instructions use technical jargon, it creates a second learning barrier as the user has to decode the complex words before they can actually understand what to do. By using clear, goal-focused vocabulary, the guide keeps users focused entirely on their lifestyle objectives (saving time and organizing outfits) rather than how the database works. Framing the instructions like a friendly, conversational story turns a dry manual into an inviting experience, boosting user confidence right away.

4. Split visuals

- **The Decision:** The presentation format was designed to split the user's focus between live on-camera narration and a clear digital screen-recording walkthrough of the app's interface.



- **The Why:** A completely text-based manual or a silent screen recording can feel repetitive and cold. According to Mayer's Cognitive Theory of Multimedia Learning (2009), people learn more deeply from words and pictures together than from words alone, especially when using separate channels for visual and auditory information. Combining live speaking with digital visuals humanizes the technology, building an immediate personal connection with the user. It allows the presenter to show the real-world, physical effort required (like laying out a shirt) while seamlessly demonstrating the digital screen progression. This dynamic shift keeps the audience

highly engaged, lowers their learning anxiety, and makes the entire onboarding process feel accessible and supportive.

Conclusion:

The success of Alta ultimately relies on its ability to quickly convince busy users that a small initial time investment will yield a massive long-term return in daily organization and a boost in confidence.

Instructions shouldn't be dense, dry text files; they need to feel like a natural part of the app itself. By organizing the guide step-by-step with clear headings, users can easily scan and find answers in seconds. Removing confusing jargon, grouping information by goals, and using a friendly split-screen video removes frustration and treats the user with empathy.

This presentation demonstrates that good technical communication is directly tied to business health. Implementing these research-backed communication choices will directly protect user retention metrics, reduce customer service overhead, accelerate first-time user activation, and smoothly transition new downloads into loyal, lifelong brand advocates.

Expected Outcomes and Measuring Success

To validate the effectiveness of these design updates, Alta's product team should monitor three key success metrics over a 90-day post-implementation period:

1. **Onboarding Completion Rate:** A targeted goal of a 15% increase in users successfully creating their first digital look within 48 hours of download.
2. **Support Ticket Deflection:** A measurable 25% drop in incoming customer service inquiries related to "failed background crops" or automated photo-tagging issues.
3. **Feature Adoption:** An upward trend in users linking their shopping emails and using the AI calendar feature during their first week, indicating that premium capabilities are no longer hidden.

Through these measurable goals, this human-centered guide proves its value as both a learning tool and a powerful asset for business growth.

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